Security and privacy

Quill is built around the idea that your notes belong to you. This page explains what data Quill collects, how notes are protected on your device and in the cloud, and what you can do to keep a vault secure.

What Quill collects

The desktop app collects almost nothing. It never reads, uploads or analyses the content of your notes unless you turn on sync. There are only two kinds of network traffic when sync is off:

- The daily update check, which sends the app version, operating system and processor type.
- Crash reports, which are sent only if you agree when a crash happens. A crash report includes the stack trace and the list of enabled plugins, but never note content or file names.

Anonymous usage statistics are off by default. If you choose to turn them on under Settings -> Privacy, Quill counts which features are used, such as how often search is opened, without recording any text you type.

Protecting notes on your device

Notes are plain files, so they are exactly as safe as the disk they live on. For laptops, turn on full-disk encryption: BitLocker on Windows, FileVault on macOS, or LUKS on Linux. Quill does not add its own encryption to local files, because doing so would break the promise that your notes are readable by any text editor.

App lock

If other people use your computer, enable the app lock under Settings -> Privacy. Quill then asks for a PIN or your system password every time the window is opened after being idle for the time you choose. The app lock hides the window contents but does not encrypt the files, so someone with access to the disk can still read them.

Encrypted notes

For a few especially sensitive notes, Quill offers encrypted notes. An encrypted note is stored as a file ending in .qenc and can only be read inside Quill after entering its password. Encrypted notes are not indexed for search and cannot be linked from other notes.

Encryption in Quill Cloud

When you sync with Quill Cloud, notes are protected in transit with TLS 1.3. On top of that you can turn on end-to-end encryption for a vault. With end-to-end encryption on, notes are encrypted on your device before upload and the Quill team cannot read them.

How the keys work

End-to-end encryption uses a passphrase that you choose. Quill derives a key from the passphrase with Argon2id, using a random salt stored with the vault, and encrypts each file with AES-256-GCM. The passphrase itself is never sent to the server. A short verification value lets Quill tell you that a passphrase is wrong without revealing anything about the correct one.

Each device needs the passphrase once, when you first connect it to the vault. After that the derived key is kept in the operating system's credential store, such as the Windows Credential Manager or the macOS Keychain.

Losing the passphrase

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You can export all of your data from the account page at any time, as a zip file of Markdown files and attachments. Deleting your account removes your notes from the Quill Cloud servers within 30 days, including backups. Billing records are kept for seven years where tax law requires it, but they contain no note content.

Reporting a vulnerability

If you find a security problem, please report it privately to the security team rather than opening a public issue. The security page on the Quill website lists the contact address and the public key for encrypted email. Reports are acknowledged within three working days, and researchers who report valid issues are credited in the release notes unless they prefer to stay anonymous.